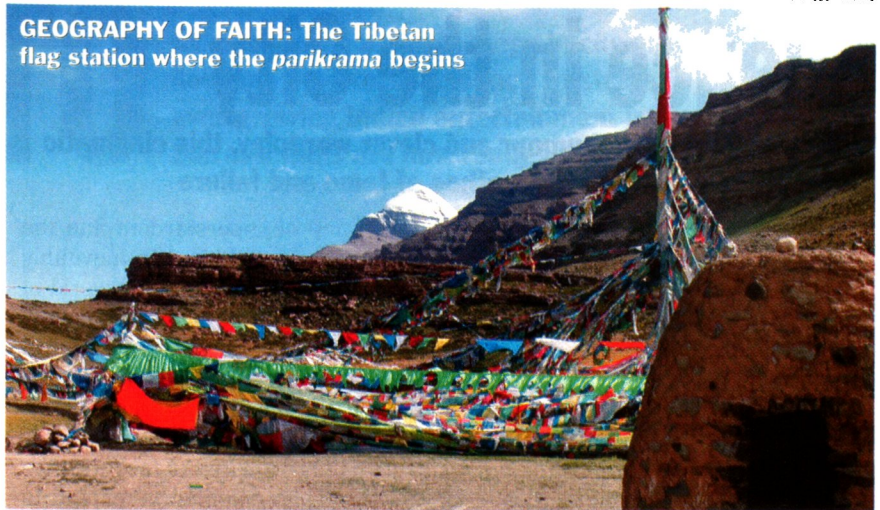


convert to his own, and is a passionate activist for the inter-faith movement. He is a doctor of metaphysics who vigorously pursues a dialogue with modern science and works hard to learn from it.

The book is not a formal biography. It stays largely with the 'global journey' and does not substantially explore or explain matters such as the mind training processes and techniques that the Dalai Lama practices and that are at the core of the Buddhist path and its secular appeal. There is brief mention of the world of esoteric Buddhism that he inhabits, the world of protective deities and spirits. Iyer describes "rival groups within Tibetan Buddhism and ancient enmities that had always cast a shadow over old Tibet now come out into the global order" as they try to undermine the Dalai Lama's tireless efforts to cultivate harmony between the different schools of Tibetan Buddhism and his celebration of diversity. The Dalai Lama, in discouraging the propitiation of the Shugden Deity amongst his followers, seemed to be going against the principle of the freedom of religion. "He argued that he felt it was proving harmful and that certain of the tenets involved in its propitiation went against the principles of Buddhism and the very tolerance and reason he was trying so hard to promote."

Iyer concludes: "Even those who you have known for an entire lifetime: at the core there is likely to be a mystery. And all that you know and learn about a person does not take away from the vast amount you cannot and will never know." The author builds on three decades of numerous personal journeys with the Dalai Lama across many continents and ideas to write an intimate, evocative portrait of the world's best known and pre-eminent icon. The book reassures us of the human potential—that true masters are those with the courage to be intensely human, to constantly engage with themselves so that they can lift their own veils of ignorance even as they urge others to do so for themselves. The Dalai Lama has the humility and the confidence to acknowledge his frailties and his struggles. The book reminds us that his journey and accomplishments could yet be our own. ■

**GEOGRAPHY OF FAITH: The Tibetan flag station where the *parikrama* begins**



# The Magic Mountain

**An unlikely agnostic pilgrim undertakes an incredibly arduous journey and hobbles to Mount Kailas to experience the unexpected**



**LIMPING TO THE CENTRE OF THE WORLD**

by **TIMERI N. MURARI**  
Penguin

Price: Rs 350; Pages: 285

■ **By Dilip Bobb**

**F**aith can move mountains but in this case, it's the other way round. Timeri Murari is a journalist-turned-author-screenwriter-playwright. His last publication was *My Temporary Son*, a factual account of Bhima, an orphan with a life-threatening deformity abandoned by his parents. Murari's wife raises money for an operation and the child enters their home and their hearts. He is adopted by a European couple, who take him for surgery, a high-risk procedure. Murari spots an advertisement for the pilgrimage to Mount Kailas, the ultimate spiritual experience for Hindus. Mount Kailas, the Crystal Mountain, is located in a remote part of Tibet under Chinese control. Hindus, Buddhists and Jains consider it the Centre of the Universe. The mystical mount has attracted thousands of pilgrims in search of miracles or nirvana, the definitive spiritual quest.

It is a quest not for the faint-hearted. Many pilgrims, including danseuse Protima Bedi, have lost their lives on the yatra. It involves a 200-km trek over

gruelling terrain in freezing cold and snow before one can circle the mountain. Murari is an unlikely pilgrim, an agnostic with a distrust of organised religion. He also has a dodgy knee and never trekked in his life. The hope that the pilgrimage will give him a chance to pray for the success of Bhima's operation moves him to the mountain. This is his account of the pilgrimage and the epiphany he experiences. Others have written on the pilgrimage to Mount Kailas, but they were historians, adventurers or true believers. This is a dispassionate account of the incredibly arduous journey, the pilgrims who form a microcosm of Indian society ("never happy unless they are complaining about something"), the complexities of the journey, including the harsh reality of Tibet, and finally, the moment when the magic mountain appears out of the mist and the trance-like awe and spiritual ecstasy induced by the *parikrama*. It's a lively read, engrossing in places, and an ideal guide for those planning to undertake the pilgrimage. Murari's transformation from sceptic to part-believer, and how the cathartic experience changes him as a person, is worth reading. Above all, it offers a valuable insight into why a remote mountain in another country continues to inspire thousands of Indians to undertake the toughest pilgrimage on earth. ■